

ON MAX CHARGE

The defending champion produced a stunning race in Baku to get his **second win in a row**, slashing the championship gap to within 70 points.

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Around the brutally narrow streets of Baku, there is virtually no margin for error. The unique blend of long straights and tight, unforgiving corners pushes Formula One drivers to their limits of skill and precision. The eighth running of the Azerbaijan Grand Prix came at a pivotal moment in the 2025 season and delivered a spectacle far from ordinary. If there is one driver who knows how to summon pace in the most difficult moments, it is the reigning world champion, Max Verstappen. Once doubtful whether his Red Bull could catch the front-running McLarens, the Dutchman silenced all concerns with a long-lost Grand Slam — pole, fastest lap, victory, and every lap led — an emphatic reminder of his pedigree.

Fresh from his triumph at Monza, Verstappen never put a wheel wrong, capitalising fully on a chaotic, mistake-ridden weekend for McLaren. For the papaya outfit, what looked like a smooth march to a second consecutive constructors' crown was forcefully delayed under the weight of errors and misfortune.

Joining Verstappen on the podium were Mercedes' George Russell and a surprise name — Carlos Sainz. The Spaniard delivered Williams its first podium since 2021, and his own maiden rostrum with the Mercedes-powered squad. The result was a landmark for the nine-time constructors' champion: its biggest points haul in a single weekend (15) since beginning its climb back from the depths of the grid.

Championship implications

For Oscar Piastri, however, Baku brought only heartbreak. After promising pace early in the weekend, the Australian fell victim to the circuit's ruthless nature — first crashing in qualifying, then bowing out on lap one of the race after a poor getaway. His struggles allowed teammate Lando

